Life often begins where no one can see it.

There may be more life here than you can see. God can be at work long before the fruit becomes visible. What begins beneath the surface, or seems small enough to overlook, may still carry the life of His Kingdom.

Jesus taught that the same seed can encounter very different soil. Some growth appears quickly but never develops deep roots. Some life is slowly crowded out. Other seed takes root, matures, and becomes fruitful.

Faithful leadership pays attention to both the seed and the soil.

Some life begins quietly: in a prayer no one hears, a relationship beginning to heal, a neighbor starting to trust, or someone taking one small step toward Jesus. Those beginnings matter.

Our responsibility is not to force growth or manufacture fruit. It is to sow faithfully, recognize what is hardening the soil or choking life, tend what God is growing, and trust Him with the harvest.

Hidden growth is not a reason to avoid honest evaluation. Look carefully. Listen honestly. Pray. Listen for Jesus through His Word, and remain open to the wisdom He may bring through the people God has placed around you. Recognize what needs tending, confront what is causing harm, and release what is consuming life without bearing fruit.

You do not have to discern this alone. The Holy Spirit is leading you, and God has placed people around you who can help you see what no one person can see alone.

Scripture for reflection: Matthew 13:1-23; Mark 4:1-20, 26-29; Luke 8:4-15; Luke 13:18-19.

The Heartbeat

Read John 15:1-17 together, giving particular attention to verses 1-5 and 9-17.

Jesus says, “Remain in me, as I also remain in you.”

John 15:4, NIV, excerpt.

He is speaking to His disciples about life in Him, bearing fruit, obedience, and love. Our work together begins there.

We want a church rooted in Christ, alive through the Holy Spirit, tended by the Father, and bearing fruit that reaches people with the saving grace of Jesus.

Systems do not create life. Jesus does. Healthy systems make room for the life He is already growing.

That is the conviction we bring to this work. Is the way we're doing ministry helping people live and serve faithfully, or are people spending all their strength keeping the activity going?

Walking through the image

Rooted. Look beneath the surface before deciding that little is happening.

Awakening. Notice and protect the first signs of trust, healing, learning, and service.

Flourishing. People have room to grow, serve, and breathe. Responsibilities are clear, help is available, and honest limits can be heard without shame.

Fruitful. Look beyond attendance. Are people following Jesus, growing in love, serving their neighbors, and sharing the good news of Christ?

Multiplying. Life reaches beyond the people who began the work. Those who were welcomed begin welcoming; those who were equipped begin helping others grow.

This is a picture of seasons, not a scorecard. Different parts of the same church may look different right now. We are not trying to hurry growth; we are learning what needs tending.

Questions worth sitting with

1. Where do we see the life of Christ in our church today? What stories help us see it?
2. Who has room to grow and serve, and who is quietly carrying more than they can sustain? Have we asked them?
3. Where are we loving people beyond our doors, and where do we need to listen before deciding how to serve?

Putting this into practice

Use a conversation the team already has scheduled. Choose one real example of life taking root and ask the people involved what is helping and what is getting in the way.

Pray together. Listen for Jesus through His Word, and remain open to the wisdom He may bring through the people God has placed around you. If something needs attention, agree on one response and the support it requires: protect what is working, share responsibility, simplify a process, or stop something harmful. It does not have to mean starting another ministry.

If the work is healthy and the people carrying it have what they need, let it continue. No extra assignment is required to prove that the conversation mattered.

Moving into the next chapter

As we look for life in the church, the people carrying its leadership belong in the conversation too. Their faithfulness may be visible while the cost remains hidden.

Who knows the soul beneath the role?

That brings us to **A Pastor Can Be Known and Still Unsupported**.

Presenter notes

- Let people look at the visual before explaining it. Ask what they notice. Give them time to answer without correcting their first impression.
- Read the Scripture from a Bible. The short John 15:4 excerpt above is exact NIV wording; every other sentence on the sheet is reflection and practical application, not rewritten Scripture.
- The parable of the sower sharpens discernment about how the word is received, what chokes life, and what becomes fruitful. It is not a five-stage organizational model and should not be used to rank people or ministries.
- "Life often begins where no one can see it" names a hopeful possibility, not a declaration that every quiet or struggling ministry is healthy. Neglect, wrongdoing, unsafe practices, and real exhaustion need an appropriate response.
- Call out faithful courage without flattering the room. Honor what God may be growing, and still ask what is hardening the soil, choking life, harming people, or consuming strength without bearing fruit.
- "The Holy Spirit is leading you" is an invitation to dependence, not permission to treat every personal impression as God's direction. Listen through Scripture and in wise community.
- Invite disagreement. Where authority or relationships could make an honest answer costly, offer a private way to contribute and explain confidentiality limits. Do not require a Pastor or volunteer to disclose personal struggles in the group.
- Do not treat the people in the picture as resources to harvest. Multiplication includes their formation, willingness, capacity, and care. Do not label overwork as sacrifice and make it untouchable.
- No Barna statistic has been added. This opening chapter establishes our understanding of life and health; research belongs where it helps the specific conversation rather than decorating every chapter.

Scripture and image boundaries

The tree landscape is our illustration, not Jesus' vine metaphor reproduced literally, and not a five-stage biblical model.

- **John 15:1-17:** Jesus identifies Himself as the vine and the Father as gardener. Read the connection between remaining, fruit, obedience, and love; do not turn pruning into permission to treat people as disposable.
- **Matthew 13:1-23; Mark 4:1-20; Luke 8:4-15:** Jesus explains different responses to the word. The good soil is the receptive hearer, not an organizational process or a member of the Trinity.
- **Mark 4:26-29:** The growing seed calls attention to growth beyond human control. It does not promise that a consulting process will produce numerical church growth.
- **Luke 13:18-19:** The mustard seed reveals the surprising reach of God's Kingdom from a small beginning. It is not a promise that every small program will become large.

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